

ADVERTISING EFFECTIVENESS ANALYSIS

Reaching St. Louis: A Social Media Campaign for the Circularity District

CircularSTL & Circularity District Task Force



Joselyn Garcia | Maddie Elhaik | Gia Grillo

Executive Summary

This report evaluates the effectiveness of a sample social media advertising campaign created to promote CircularSTL's proposed Circularity District in St. Louis. The campaign was designed to raise public awareness and communicate the message that unused household items represent recoverable financial and community value and should remain in circulation rather than ending up in landfills. This goal directly reflects the circular economy framework, which prioritizes keeping materials in use for as long as possible, in direct contrast to the dominant linear take-make-discard model prevalent today.

We started by evaluating three advertising formats: social media, posters, and emails. After our research, we selected Instagram as the platform for our campaign. We developed the hashtag "#AroundSTL" and tagline "What goes around should come back around" as key concepts in our campaign. We assessed the ad through a 16-question survey distributed to 31 respondents between April 17-21, 2026. Respondents ranged in age from 18 to 55 and represented a mix of St. Louis workers, residents, students, and individuals with no prior connection to the city.

Our findings gave us insight on what strategies in the campaign worked, and overall respondents expressed strong interest in the Circularity District. The campaign received an average compellingness score of 3.70 out of 5 and an average favorability rating of 4.15 toward respondents' opinions on the Circularity District. Approximately 80% of respondents agreed that the tagline "What goes around should come back around" conveyed a circular economy, and responses shed light on what strategies were most effective in the advertisement. The concept of the Circularity District itself was described overwhelmingly as "great," "useful," and "needed."

The survey responses also revealed key gaps and room for growth in our campaign. Only 10% of respondents felt the campaign was distinctly rooted in St. Louis, and several expressed uncertainty about what the Circularity District is and how it differs from existing models like Goodwill. These findings highlight the need for clearer explanation of the concept, stronger emotional engagement, and more localized messaging. This report examines our campaign, how it was received, and concludes with recommendations for potential future campaigns to improve clarity, strengthen audience connection, and increase the likelihood of community participation and support for the Circularity District.

Introduction

The objective of this study was to conduct an advertising effectiveness analysis. We began by researching successful advertising strategies used by major enterprises, including ² Patagonia's "Don't Buy This Jacket" campaign and ³ Nike's "Move to Zero" campaign, to understand how these brands create ads that generate awareness and engagement. ⁶ From there, we used those insights to design our own approach, with the goal of building awareness of the Circularity District and communicating one core idea: keep items circulating in St. Louis instead of ending up in landfills. Our core research questions were what makes a Circularity District feel valuable in the eyes of consumers, and how advertising can highlight that value in a way that feels relevant and motivating.

¹The campaign's strategic direction was shaped decisively by the Ellen MacArthur Foundation's The Marketing Playbook for a Circular Economy, which identifies "Make circular behaviors irresistible" as

one of the key actions required to shift consumer preference and behavior at scale. This principle anchored our approach: by framing the Circularity District as an economical gain for consumers, we designed the campaign to make participation feel desirable, financially smart, and personally relevant to everyday St. Louis residents.

The methodology began with researching three advertising formats, social media, posters, and email, to determine which channel would best reach the district's target audience.⁶ We also studied Circular STL's mission and prior Symposium reports, where a clear trend emerged: a pressing need for education, outreach, and a shift in public understanding.⁶ Action Area 6 of the 2025 Symposium Report states that "Maintaining consistent, non-partisan, relatable messaging is essential to shift public understanding, reduce silos, and build a strong culture of reuse, recycling, and composting." This made clear that the messaging gap was a significant barrier, and that clarity and relatability would need to be at the core of any effective campaign. To ground our campaign in a compelling financial hook, we drew on⁴ OfferUp's 2025 Recommerce Report, which found that 93% of Americans bought secondhand in 2025 and provided the \$3,100 statistic representing the average value of unused household clutter. We structured the campaign around a rule of four: a relatable hook, statistics, a brief overview of what the Circularity District offers, and a call to action anchored by a shareable hashtag designed to build community momentum. From there, we deployed an in-depth survey to 31 community members between April 17 and 21, 2026, collecting quantitative ratings and qualitative feedback on comprehension, emotional response, and overall perception of the campaign and the Circularity District concept. Findings, analysis, and recommended next steps are presented in the sections that follow.

Advertising Research and Format Selection

Before developing the campaign, we evaluated three advertising formats to identify which would best serve Circular STL's goal of broad public awareness and community participation.¹ This evaluation was guided by a core insight from the Ellen MacArthur Foundation's *The Marketing Playbook for a Circular Economy*: that effective circular economy communication must make sustainable behaviors feel irresistible.

Posters

Physical posters can be a meaningful tool for brand visibility, particularly in high-traffic locations such as college campuses and transit corridors.⁹ According to the Nielsen OAAA Poster Advertising Study, 71% of adults ages 25-34 reported noticing a poster in the past month, and the average ad recall rate across tested campaigns was 47%. Campaigns featuring a clear call-to-action, such as a QR code linking to further information, generated higher recall than awareness-only ads. For a sustainability initiative like the Circularity District, posters placed in high-footfall areas could serve as a low-cost entry point for reaching younger, sustainability-engaged audiences. However, posters are geographically fixed and limited in demographic reach. The Circularity District is intended to serve all strata of the St. Louis community across multiple jurisdictions, and posters were therefore not selected as the primary strategy for this campaign.

Email Outreach

Email marketing offers well-documented advantages in cost efficiency and targeting precision. Campaign Monitor research shows that segmented campaigns can drive up to 760% more revenue than

non-segmented ones, and personalized subject lines increase open rates by 26%. HubSpot data reports an average return of \$36 for every \$1 spent on email marketing. However, email requires a pre-existing audience to be effective. Mailchimp industry benchmarks show average open rates of only 20-25% and click-through rates of just 2-3% across industries. For a campaign requiring broad new reach, this represents a low-effort, low-gain situation. Email was therefore identified as best suited for retaining and deepening engagement with audiences already familiar with the District, rather than generating new awareness.

Social Media

Social media emerged as the most effective format for the current immediate communication needs. Platforms like Instagram enable precise geographic targeting, allowing content to reach St. Louis area audiences while building scalable public awareness simultaneously.⁷ According to NewMedia's 200+ Social Media Marketing Statistics, hashtag use on Instagram increases reach by an average of 12%, and brand mentions on social media grew by 21% in recent years. Visual content drives ten times more engagement than text-only posts, reinforcing the case for a visual-first creative approach.

Social media enables the two-way community dialogue essential for behavior change campaigns.⁸ Research on social media's role in the circular economy notes that these platforms allow organizations to connect emotionally with their audiences in ways that drive meaningful shifts toward more sustainable practices. This storytelling function is especially important for the Circularity District, which must not only introduce a new concept but motivate residents to change how they dispose of and acquire goods. The Ellen MacArthur Foundation similarly emphasizes making circular alternatives feel personally relevant and easy to act on, qualities that social media delivers at scale.

Format Decision

After evaluating all three formats, we selected social media as the primary advertising channel. It offers the broadest reach, the strongest tools for building brand awareness, and the greatest potential for building community momentum around the Circularity District. Email is recommended as a complementary strategy once social media has established initial public awareness.

#AroundSTL Campaign

Drawing on insights from successful circular economy campaigns including² Patagonia's #BuyLessDemandMore and³ Nike's "Move to Zero" initiative, we developed a four-post Instagram carousel designed to introduce the Circularity District to a broad St. Louis audience in a relatable, financially motivating way. The campaign was structured around the triple bottom line framework, measuring value across three dimensions: people, planet, and profit. Each post speaks to at least one of these dimensions, community benefit (people), waste reduction (planet), and financial value recovery (profit), so the campaign appeals to a wide range of motivations rather than relying solely on environmental altruism.

The campaign's overarching tagline, "What goes around should come back around," was chosen as a nod to community sayings similar to "In St. Louis, For St. Louis," and was also inspired by the ethos of luxury resale brand⁵ What Goes Around Comes Around (WGACA), whose entire brand identity is built around

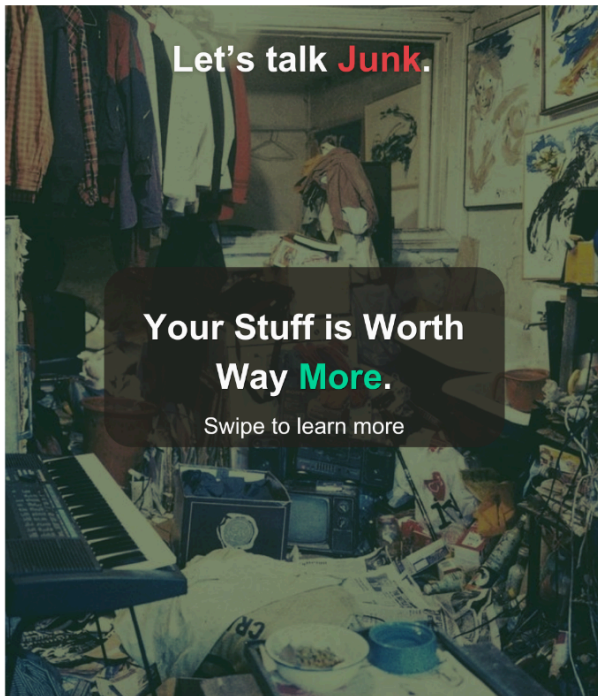
the idea that quality items deserve a second life. We added our own twist, where the "around" aspect subtly hints at circularity while feeling native to St. Louis culture. The hashtag #WhatGoesAroundSTL was designed to be memorable and location-specific, inviting residents to participate in a shared community conversation where they could showcase sending their useful clutter back around to those who may have use for it.

The four-post structure followed a deliberate narrative arc (Exhibit 1):

- Post 1, The Hook: "**Your Stuff is Worth Way More**" is an immediate attention grab designed to reframe how residents think about their unused items before anything else is said.
- Post 2, The Math: "The average household has **\$3,100** in unused items sitting in closets, garages, and forgotten corners of the house." Anchored by ⁴ OfferUp's 2025 Recommerce Report, this post pairs a financial reality check with relatable messaging to create a genuine wow moment for viewers.
- Post 3, What the District Does: A straightforward breakdown of what the District offers, donate, repair, circulate, with the key emphasis on "all in one place." We wanted to highlight the convenience and duality this District could bring to the community.
- Post 4, The Call to Action: "**In St. Louis, what goes around should come back around.**" Light but strong, this closing message conveys optimism and encourages residents to think about recirculation. If deployed as a paid Instagram ad, a learn more link bar directing viewers to the CircularSTL website would be implemented here.

The campaign's visual identity used a combination of red, green, and muted tones to serve a deliberate purpose: red was used to emphasize statistics and create urgency, green to signal sustainability and the positive outcome, and the muted tones to ground the overall aesthetic. This color psychology was intended to embed a subconscious association between the problem and the solution for viewers. A visualization of clutter was also incorporated to reinforce the relatability of the message and prompt personal reflection. Bold white typography was chosen for mobile readability. The primary hashtag #WhatGoesAroundSTL anchors the campaign, with additional options including #CircularSTL, #KeepItInMotion, and #NoMoreJunk available to expand reach and community engagement.

Exhibit 1: #WhatGoesAroundSTL Campaign: Four-Post Instagram Carousel



Let's talk **Junk.**

Your Stuff is Worth
Way **More.**

Swipe to learn more

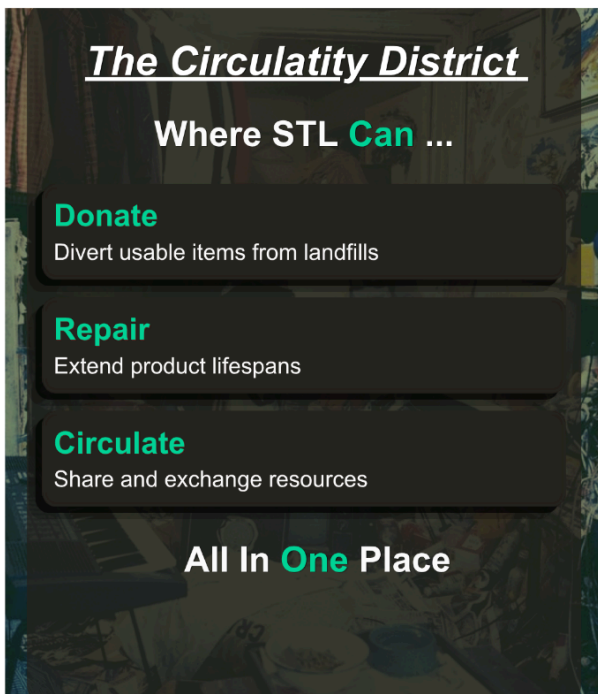


The Average Household has

\$3,100

in **unused** items sitting in closets,
garages, and forgotten corners of the
house.

54% of Americans
are overwhelmed by clutter — and 78%
have no idea what to do with it



The Circulativity District

Where STL **Can ...**

Donate

Divert usable items from landfills

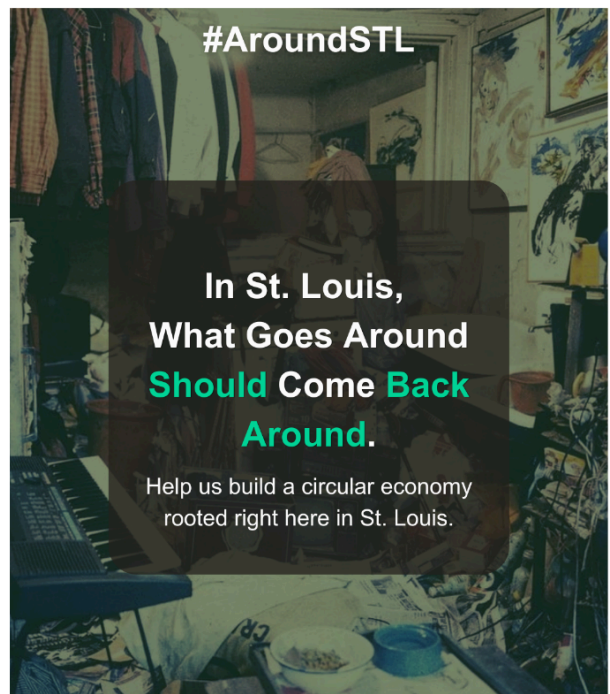
Repair

Extend product lifespans

Circulate

Share and exchange resources

All In **One Place**



#AroundSTL

In St. Louis,
What Goes Around
**Should Come Back
Around.**

Help us build a circular economy
rooted right here in St. Louis.

Survey Methodology

To assess the effectiveness of our campaign and audience response, we developed and distributed a 16-question mixed-methods survey. The survey included both quantitative questions, measured on a one to five star scale, and qualitative questions, collected through open-ended responses.

Before viewing the campaign, respondents answered baseline questions about their familiarity with CircularSTL, the circular economy concept, and their personal engagement with secondhand goods. After viewing all four posts, they rated the campaign across multiple dimensions and answered open-ended questions about specific slides, clarity, and suggestions for improvement. This before-and-after structure allowed the team to isolate the campaign's effect on awareness and attitude.

The survey was distributed directly via private message to students (at WashU), faculty, friends, and coworkers between April 17 and 21, 2026, and collected 31 complete responses. Respondents ranged in age from 18 to 55 and included St. Louis residents, students and workers in the area, and individuals with no prior connection to the city.

This study carries important limitations that should be noted. The sample of 31 respondents was not randomly selected and was recruited through personal and social networks, which may skew results toward individuals already open to sustainability topics. Additionally, the sample size limits statistical generalizability and because respondents viewed a prototype campaign rather than encountering it organically on social media, the engagement context differs from a real deployment of the ad. These limitations should be considered in interpreting findings and planning next steps.

Survey Findings

Awareness of Respondents

The majority of respondents had little to no prior awareness of Circular STL or the circular economy before completing the survey. Most rated their familiarity with Circular STL a 1 out of 5, indicating they had never heard of the organization. Familiarity with the term “circular economy” was similarly low for most participants, though some older St. Louis residents showed stronger baseline knowledge.

Despite not many people having prior knowledge of Circular STL, respondents reported moderate to high personal engagement with secondhand activity. Many indicated that donating or repurposing unused household items was personally important to them. This predisposed motivation for sustainability would help significantly in marketing Circular STL as it shows that the consumers values align. This gap between behavior and awareness is where strategic advertising can make the greatest difference.

Comprehension and Message Clarity

After viewing the campaign, the majority of respondents reported a clearer understanding of what a Circularity District is and does. Respondents described it in terms such as “a whole system designed to keep things moving” and “a place where you can drop off, fix up, borrow, or repurpose just about

anything.” Several expressed that they wanted to learn more about the Circularity district from just one campaign. The core message that unused items should stay in circulation rather than going to waste was consistently understood across age groups.

Some respondents had more questions about how the District would operate in practice. One respondent asked directly, “What is the main purpose of the Circulatory District? Is it just to remove waste and reuse or recycle, or is there a greater purpose?” This feedback reveals that the sample campaign made them interested in the Circularity District, but also left them with questions about what exactly it does.

Most Impactful Element: Financial Framing

The single most impactful element across the entire campaign was the financial statistic in Post 2. Approximately 35% of respondents identified this slide as the most memorable, with 25% each selecting Posts 3 and 4. The statement “The \$3,100 statistic made me think about my own unused items” was agreed upon by approximately 75% of all respondents.

Respondents described the \$3,100 figure as prompting personal reflection on their own consumption and creating a sense of financial opportunity. One stated that, “Putting numbers made me reflect on how much I actually consume versus how much I use.” Another observed that the visual in the slide “gave urgency.” This finding validates financial framing as a primary messaging strategy and reflects the triple bottom line in action that by connecting the personal profit dimension of circularity to the broader environmental and community benefits, the campaign made sustainability feel immediately relevant to the individual rather than abstract.

Attitudinal and Emotional Response

Respondents reacted positively to both the campaign and the Circularity District concept. The overall impression of CircularSTL averaged 4.15 out of 5. This suggests that even a prototype campaign can generate meaningful organizational goodwill. The concept itself was described overwhelmingly in favorable terms, with many respondents noting its potential to reduce waste, support lower-income community members, and create a more sustainable city.

Statement Agreement

The survey had respondents select statements they agreed with after viewing the campaign. The tagline and financial statistic performed strongly, with approximately 80% and 75% agreement respectively, and 75% found the statistics credible. The most significant gap was seen in the St. Louis aspect of the campaign. Only approximately 10% agreed that the campaign felt distinctly rooted in St. Louis rather than generic. For a campaign whose core proposition is keeping value in the St. Louis community, this represents the most actionable area for improvement.

Qualitative Feedback

Open-ended responses showed several consistent themes. Multiple respondents suggested that slides contained too much text for a social media post and that the wording could be more punchy and emotional. Several noted that the dark color palette was not visually striking enough to capture attention while scrolling, and that lighter backgrounds with bolder text, especially for the financial statistics, would be more effective. One respondent said that Post 2’s visual style risked appearing like spam at first glance,

which would be a concern in building trust in the campaign. Several also requested a clearer call to action and information about how to follow the District's progress toward becoming a reality.

Conclusion and Recommendations

This prototype campaign and reception analysis set out to explore how advertising can communicate the value of the Circularity District to St. Louis residents effectively and get them excited and interested in the district. The findings demonstrate that a thoughtfully framed social media campaign (even in prototype form) can meaningfully shift awareness and generate genuine enthusiasm for the concept. Respondents left the survey with a clearer understanding of the District, a more favorable view of CircularSTL, and positive outlooks toward the idea of a local circular hub.

At the same time, the findings make clear that awareness is not enough. The gap between concept enthusiasm and behavioral intent, the low score on local specificity, and the recurring questions about what the District actually would be like on the ground all point to areas for improvement in communication. The Circularity District is an inherently place-based proposition, as it depends on St. Louis residents engaging with it and spreading awareness. Potential future campaigns should center a sense of locality, and the fact that the Circularity District would be built for the needs and benefit of the STL community.

Based on these findings, the team offers the following recommendations to the Circular STL Circularity District Team in terms of effective advertising:

- **Lead with financial value:** the \$3,100 per-household statistic was the single most effective campaign element. Future materials should leverage their message in personal economic benefit, not just environmental impact, to reach the broadest possible audience and make the triple bottom line tangible at the individual level.
- **Strengthen St. Louis-specific identity:** Only 10% of respondents felt the campaign was distinctly rooted in STL. Future campaigns should incorporate St. Louis neighborhood references, local landmarks, STL-specific data, and community partner callouts to build the local pride and belonging that will get the community excited about a local circularity hub.
- **Identify a competitive edge:** Emphasize what differentiates CircularSTL's hub concept from places like Goodwill. Several respondents conflated the District with Goodwill or basic recycling. A clear visual post or linked landing page should differentiate the District's full-service hub model and build a strong understanding of why this is important.
- **Refine visual design:** Social media content is consumed in seconds; each slide should communicate one idea in a few words, with **strong** visuals doing the explanatory work. Respondents recommended brighter colors, bolder typography for statistics, and reduced text per slide.
- **Add a specific and immediate call to action:** several respondents asked where they could go, sign up, or follow progress. Future campaigns should direct audiences to a specific next step, for example a website, mailing list signup, or community event, to convert interest into engagement before momentum fades. When utilizing social media advertising features, having a "learn more" bar is attainable.

The Circularity District represents a meaningful opportunity to reshape how St. Louis residents think about waste, value, and community. This study demonstrates that a well-designed social media campaign can introduce that vision compellingly, and that with refinements to local specificity, visual design, and clarity of concept, advertising can be a powerful tool for CircularSTL's development of their Circularity District

References

1. Ellen MacArthur Foundation and Kantar, "The Marketing Playbook for a Circular Economy," Ellen MacArthur Foundation, November 11, 2024, <https://www.ellenmacarthurfoundation.org/marketing/overview>.
2. Tefi Alonso, "Strategy Study: How Patagonia Became The Benchmark In Sustainable Clothing," Cascade, February 9, 2023, <https://www.cascade.app/studies/patagonia-strategy-study>.
3. Benjamin Hiorns, "Green by Design: How Creative Brands Are Feeding into the Circular Economy," #SustainabilityMonth, August 4, 2024, [Green by Design: How Creative Brands Are Feeding into the Circular Economy #SustainabilityMonth](#)
4. OfferUp, "Secondhand Shopping Is Now the Norm: 93% of Americans Bought Used in 2025," PR Newswire, September 25, 2025, <https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/secondhand-shopping-is-now-the-norm-93-of-americans-bought-used-in-2025-according-to-offerups-2025-recommerce-report-302566495.html>.
5. What Goes Around Comes Around (WGACA), "New Arrivals | Shop New Designer Bags & Accessories," accessed April 24, 2026, [New Arrivals | Shop New Designer Bags & Accessories | WGACA](#)
6. CircularSTL, 2025 CircularSTL Symposium Summary Report (St. Louis: CircularSTL, 2025), <https://www.circularstl.org>.
7. NEWMEDIA.COM, "200+ Social Media Marketing Statistics (2026 Data & Trends)," accessed April 24, 2026, <https://newmedia.com/blog/social-media-marketing-statistics>.
8. Herrera, A. M. C., Cruz – Fernández, G. de la, Velásquez, , E. V. A., Alanya, F. M. T., & Yañez , E. J. P. (2024). The Evolution of Social Media Marketing and its Impact on the Circular

Economy: Business Decisions in Digital Culture. *EVOLUTIONARY STUDIES IN IMAGINATIVE CULTURE*, 287–292. <https://doi.org/10.70082/esic/8.1.20>

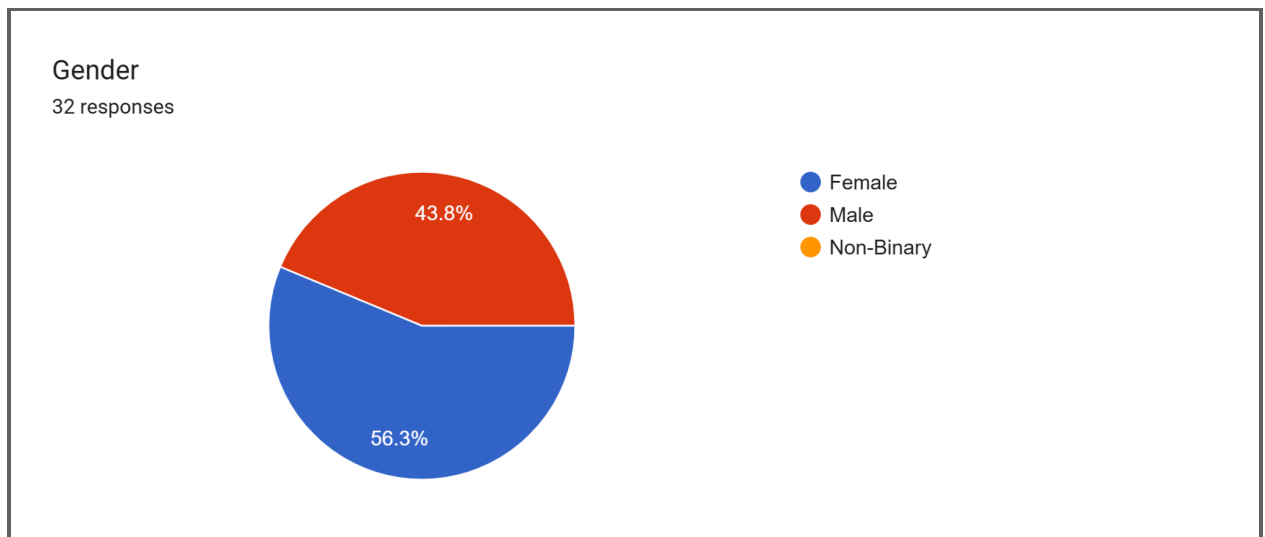
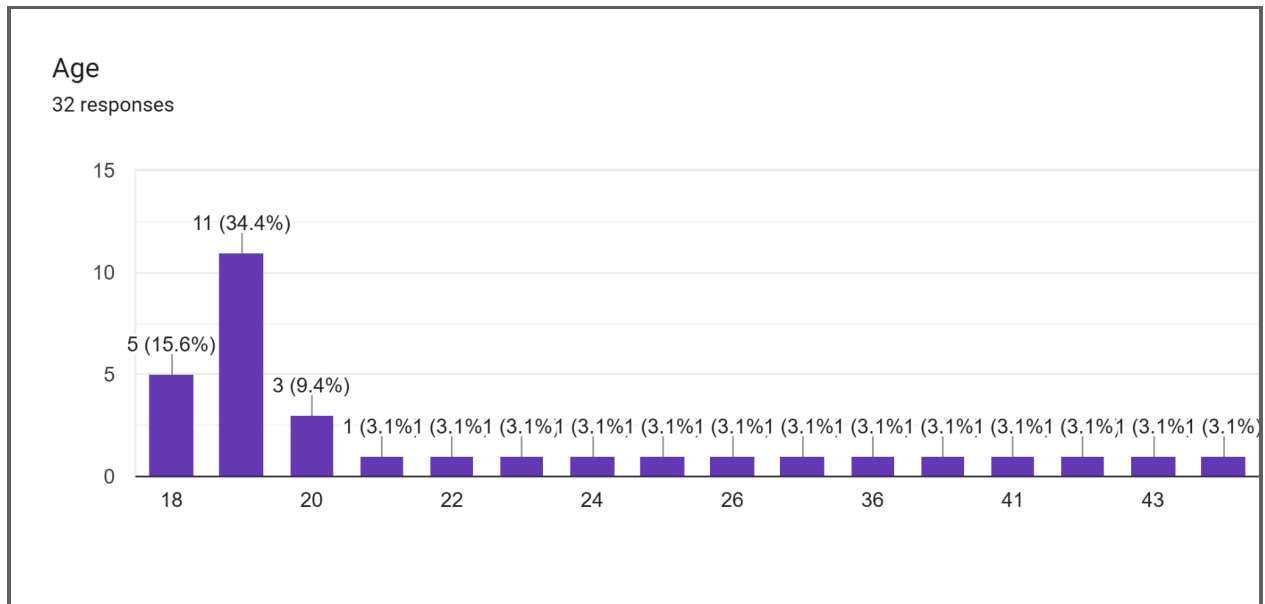
9. “Email Marketing ROI: Key Stats & Proven Effectiveness.” HubSpot Blog. Accessed April 24, 2026. <https://blog.hubspot.com/marketing/email-marketing-stats>.

Appendix

Survey Results Master Key

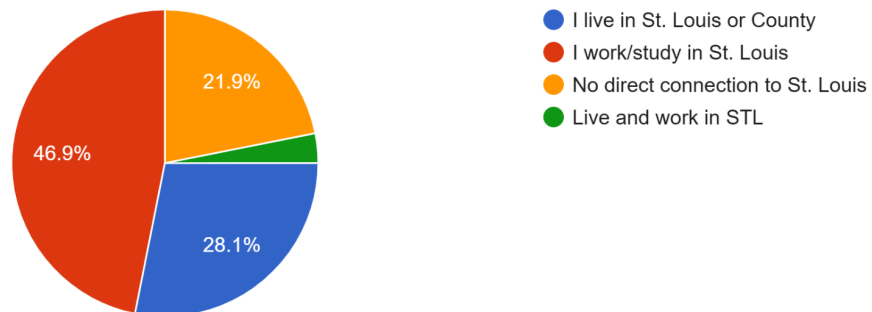
https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1mq7CreqXV3S0BPIg0r0G6Na9CJdare0udWdw-p_VyyQ/edit?usp=sharing

Survey Insights



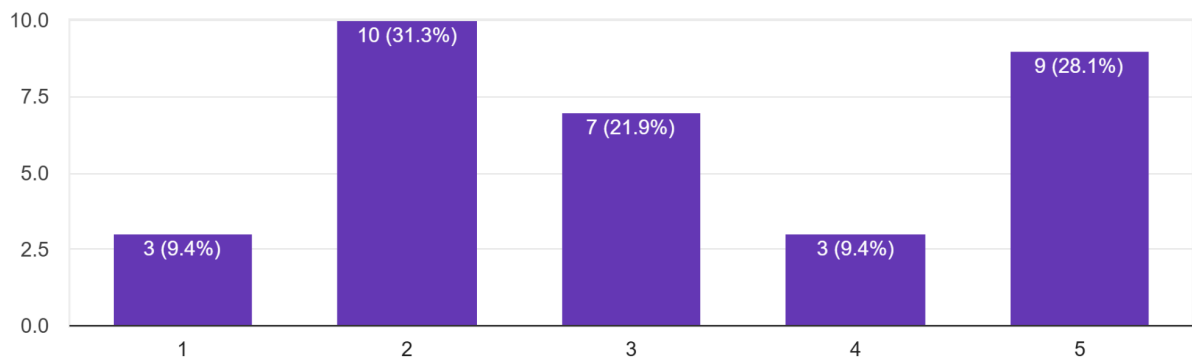
Which best describes your connection to St. Louis?

32 responses



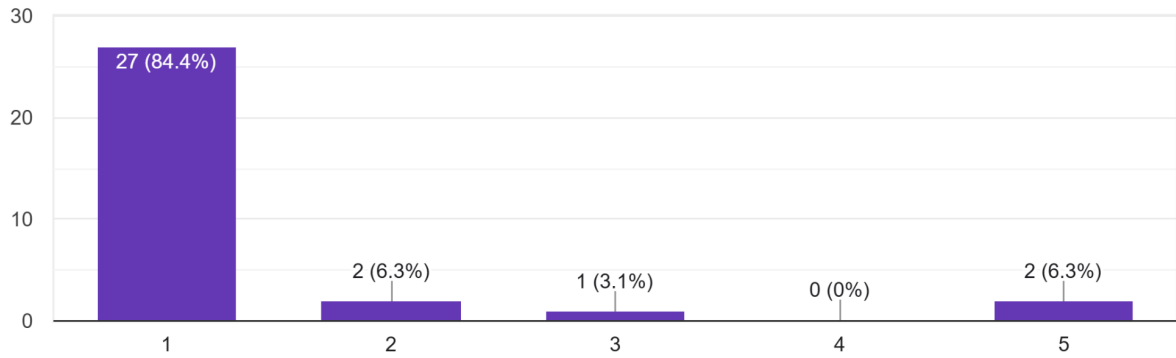
On a scale of 1–5, how often do you engage with secondhand activity: thrifting, re-selling, donating, reusing, repairing? (1 being "never", 5 meaning very often)

32 responses



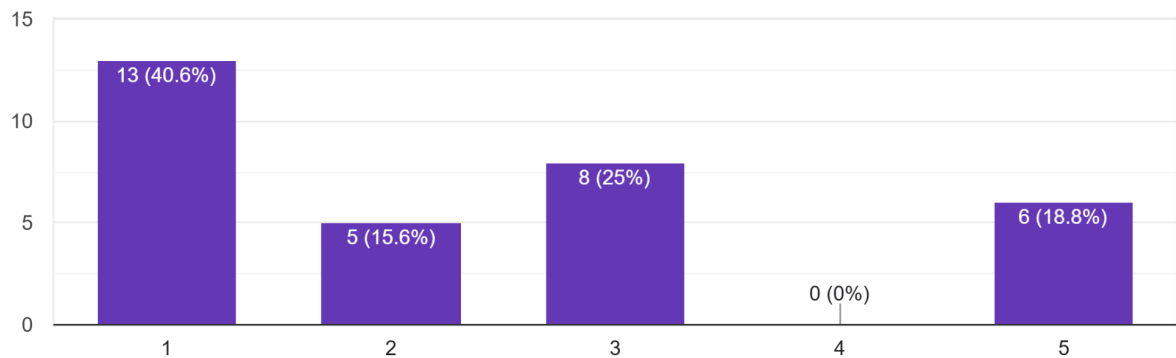
On a scale of 1 to 5, how familiar were you with CircularSTL before today? (1 meaning you've never heard of it and 5 meaning you know it very well)

32 responses



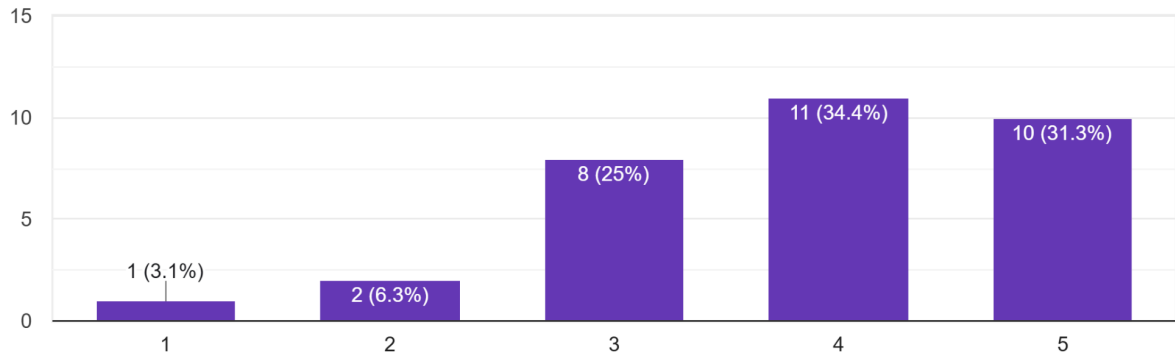
On a scale of 1 to 5, how familiar are you with the concept of a "circular economy"? (1 meaning you've never heard the term and 5 meaning you're very familiar with it)

32 responses



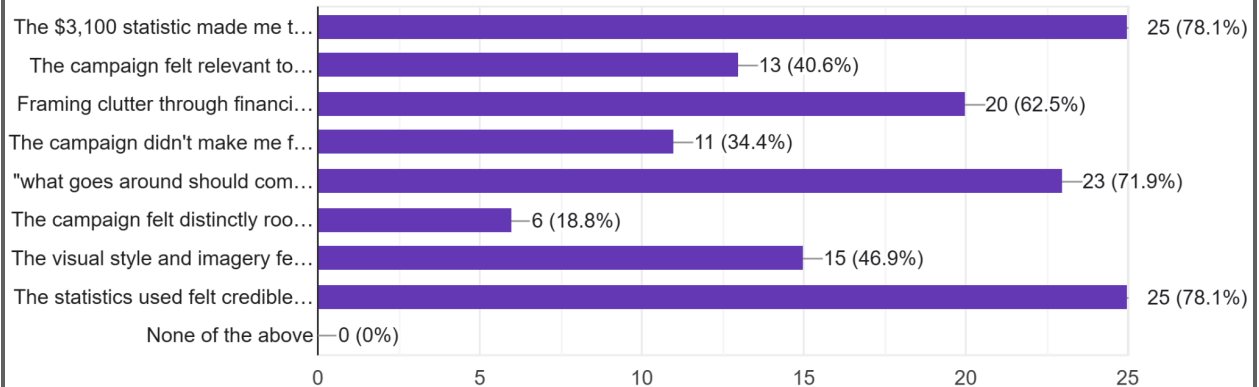
On a scale of 1 to 5, how important is donating or repurposing unused household items to you personally? (1 meaning it's not something you think ...ll and 5 meaning it's extremely important to you)

32 responses



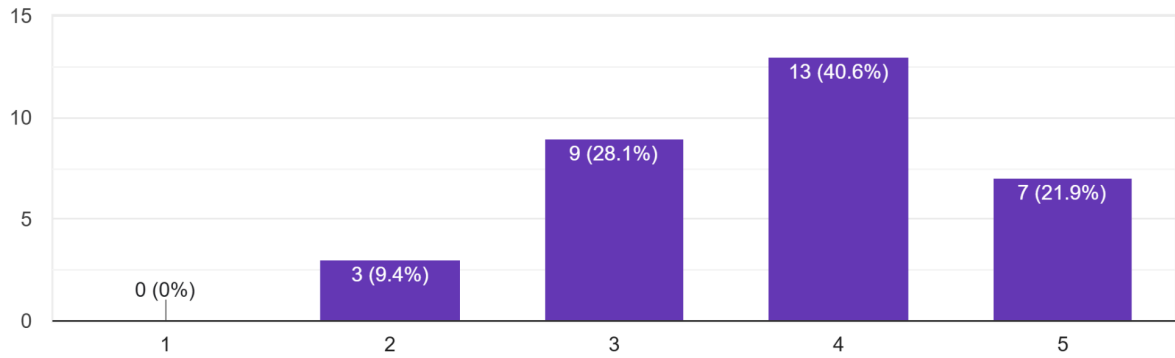
Select the statements below that you agree with:

32 responses



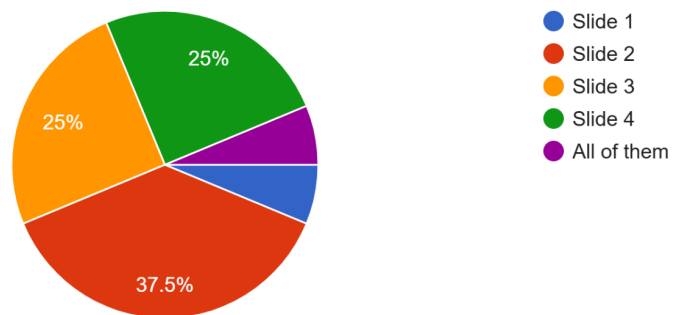
On a scale of 1 to 5, how compelling was the campaign's overall message? (1 meaning it wasn't compelling at all and 5 meaning it was extremely compelling) *

32 responses



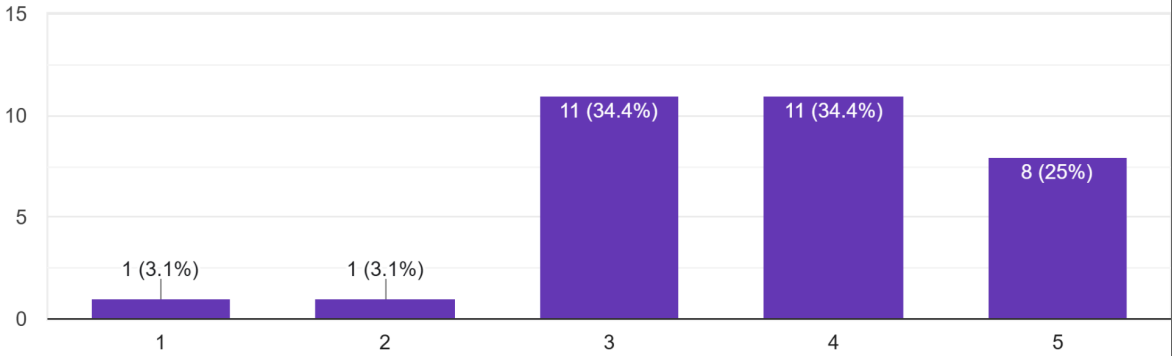
Which single slide was most impactful to you?

32 responses



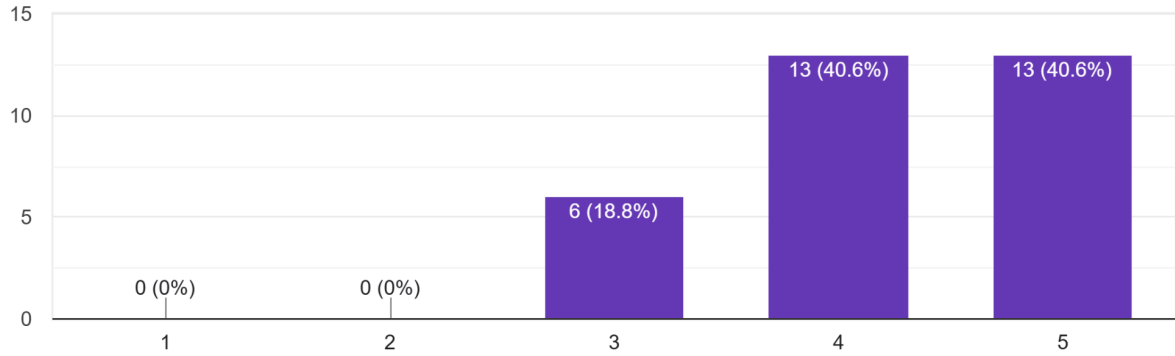
After seeing this campaign, how likely are you to look up or visit the Circularity District if it opened near you? (with 1 meaning very unlikely and 5 meaning very likely)

32 responses



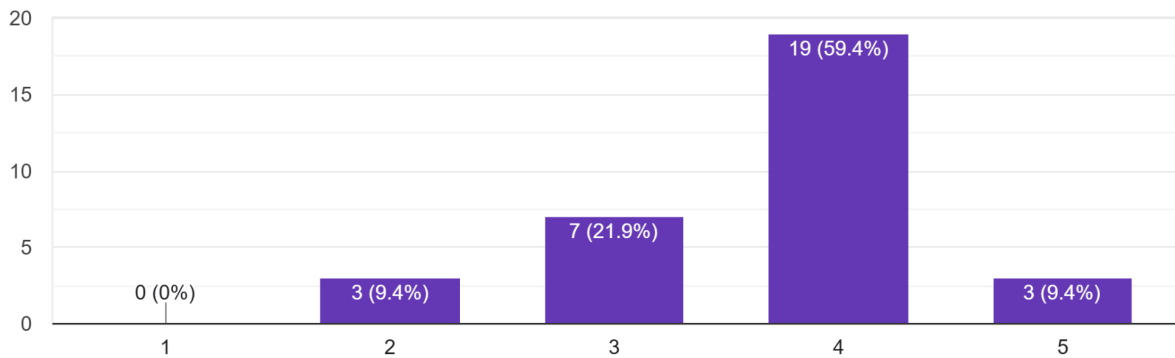
After seeing this campaign, how favorable is your overall impression of CircularSTL? (1 meaning very unfavorable and 5 meaning very favorable)

32 responses



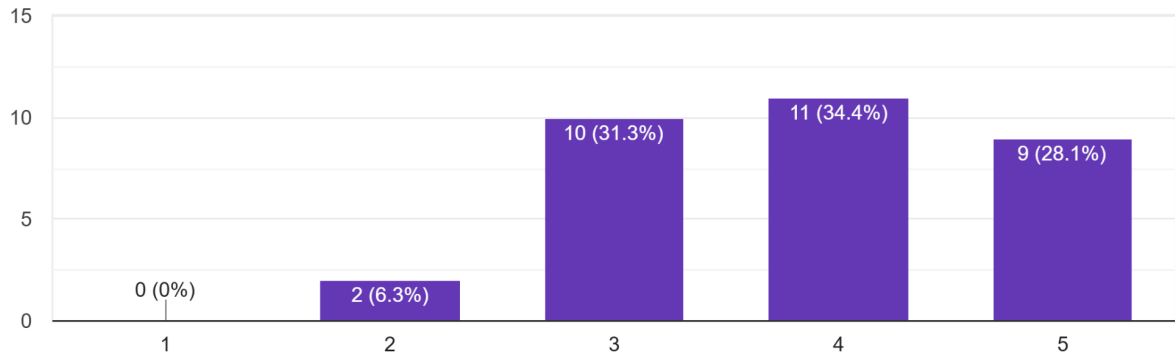
How credible does CircularSTL seem as an organization based on this campaign? (with 1 meaning not credible at all and 5 meaning very credible)

32 responses



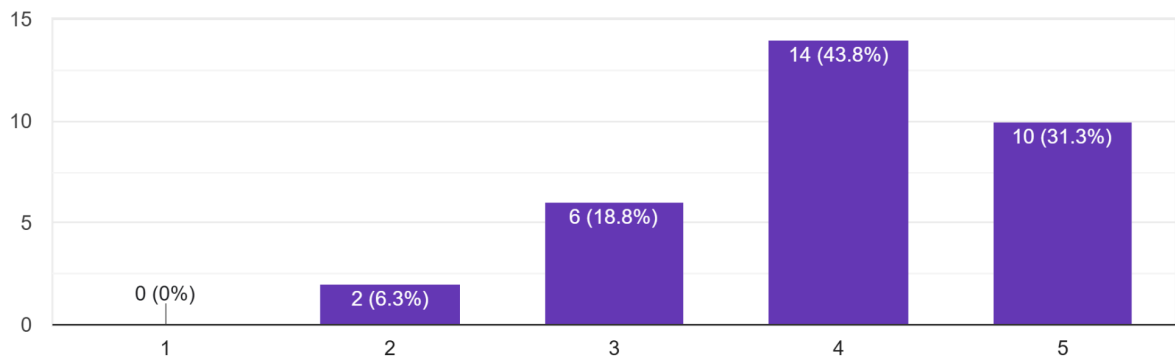
In your opinion, how well does the Circularity District concept fit the needs of the St. Louis community? (with 1 meaning it doesn't fit at all and 5 meaning it's a perfect fit)

32 responses



On a scale of 1 to 5, how would you rate the overall tone of the campaign? (with 1 meaning it felt preachy or off-putting and 5 meaning it felt convincing/inspiring/very intriguing)

32 responses



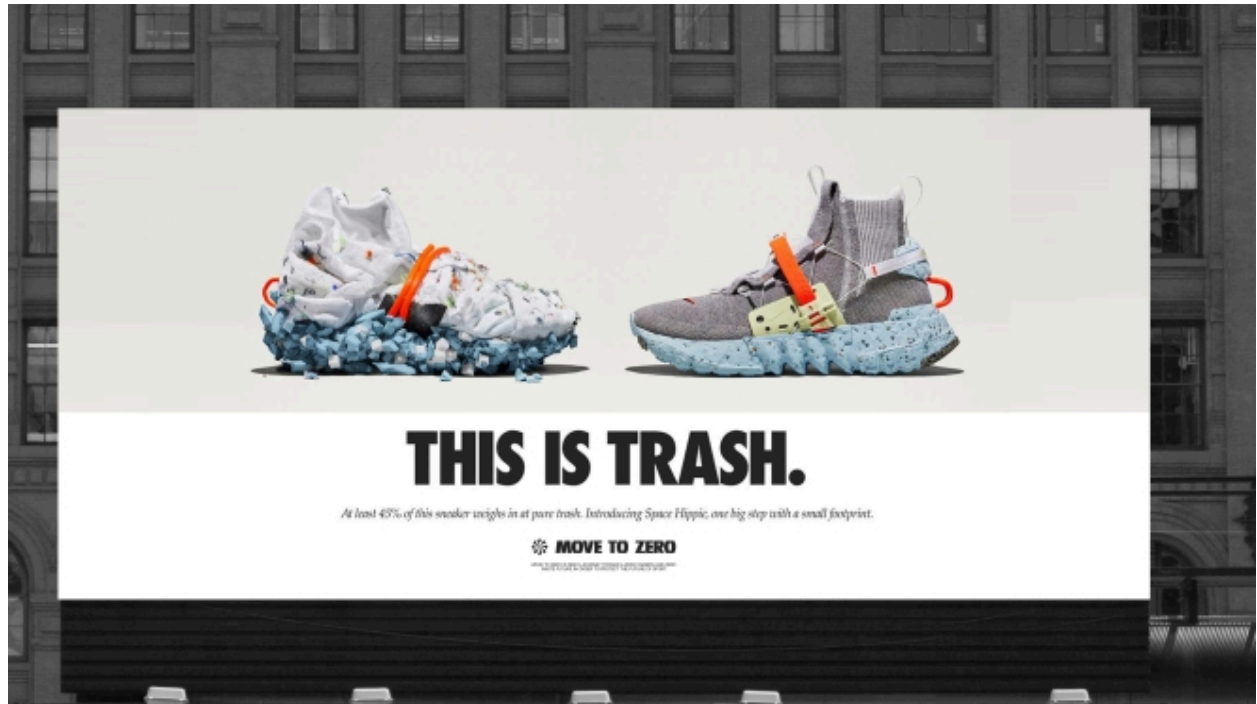
A dark, quilted jacket with a high collar and a front zipper closure. The jacket features a large, horizontal zippered pocket on the lower front and a smaller, vertical zippered pocket on the upper right chest. The material appears to be a heavy, insulated fabric, possibly nylon or polyester, with a quilted pattern. The jacket is shown against a plain, light background.



Source: *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, 93(463), 1031-1042.

1000

Patagonia's "Dont Buy This Jacket" Advertisement



Nike's "Move to Zero" Initiative Advertisement